



INA, WEB.

INTRODUCTION

In Mexico, women's access to higher education, especially indigenous women, is limited due to cultural, social, and more importantly, economic factors of their families, given that they face discrimination because of their gender and their indigenous background (UN, 2015).

Faced with the educational lag of indigenous youth, the Mexican government and Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs) have undertaken actions to promote a greater access, higher retention and support the completion of the studies of indigenous students in the Mexican higher education system (Hernández & Gibson, 2015). However, the number of indigenous women who manage to access higher education is significantly lower compared to indigenous men, and more worryingly, there are very limited educational programs focused on meeting the needs of indigenous women.

The development of Intercultural Universities and educational strategies focused on supporting indigenous students, as well as the interculturalization of conventional universities to meet indigenous women's needs, are some of the actions implemented by the Mexican Government (Hernández & Gibson, 2015). However, there is limited gender-based research that investigates the lived experiences of Mexican indigenous women, which, in turn, does not allow to identify the strengths and limitations of such educational programs and governmental strategies.

As a result, this study aimed to be innovative and pioneering by listening to and disseminating the lived experiences of indigenous women pursuing postgraduate studies in Mexico, with a view to understanding their interests and needs as postgraduate students. Additionally, this study aimed to understand how this educational program impacted indigenous women's academic and professional development from a gender perspective.

OBJECTIVES

-To gather the lived experiences and perceptions of indigenous women who completed postgraduate studies as part of the CONACYT Regional Strengthening Program in the State of Hidalgo to understand how their gender and ethnicity influence their academic experience from a Feminist perspective.

-To provide evidence of how gender and ethnicity influenced the academic experience of indigenous women to lay the foundation for future research in order to explore and better understand the academic and professional trajectories once they complete postgraduate studies.

Research question: How does gender and ethnicity influence the academic experience of program participants?

METHODOLOGY

RESEARCH DESIGN: This research employed a qualitative approach (Beiras, et al., 2017). This approach helped obtaining the lived perspectives and perceptions of the participants, as well as their group and collective interactions while studying in a postgraduate program. This helped understand and explain their complex social reality more effectively (Harding, 2012) through the intersectionality of the discriminations that participants have experienced in the program.

PARTICIPANTS: This study recruited 9 participants following a non-probabilistic sampling method as suggested by Otzen and Manterola (2017). This type of sampling allowed for the selection of participants with specific characteristics, such as their self-identification as indigenous, and, most importantly, their willingness to narrate their experiences.

MATERIALS: In-depth interviews recommended by Feria et al. (2020) were used to gather the perceptions and experiences of participants, with an emphasis on how they perceive that their gender and ethnicity influenced their active participation in the program. Based on a thorough review of the scientific literature, the interview schedule comprised 30 open-ended questions exploring factors related to gender and intersectionality, ethnicity and interculturality in higher education.

DATA ANALYSIS

All interviews were analysed using thematic analysis (Mieles, et al, 2012). However, in-depth interviews were further conducted with three participants to further explore essential factors and elements related to intersectionality and interculturality as experienced by them.

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EXPERIENCES OF INDIGENOUS WOMEN PARTICIPATING IN A REGIONAL STRENGTHENING PROGRAM “CONACYT”

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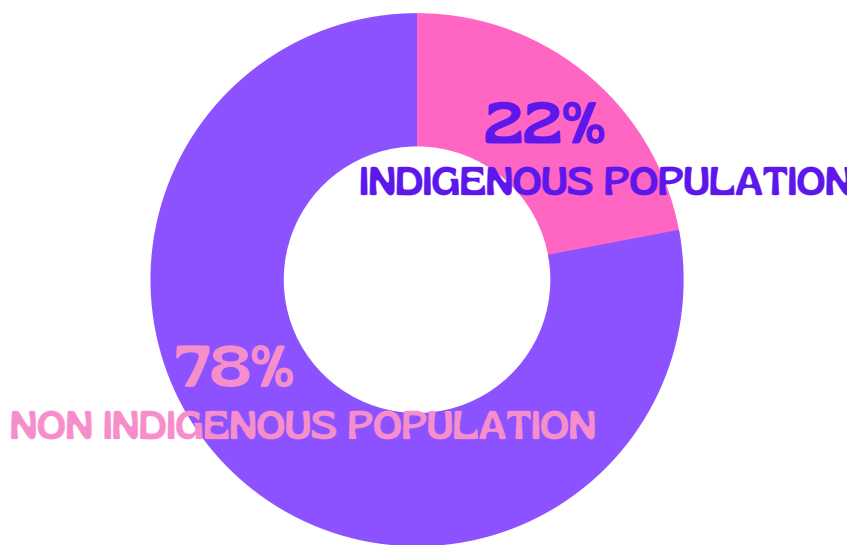
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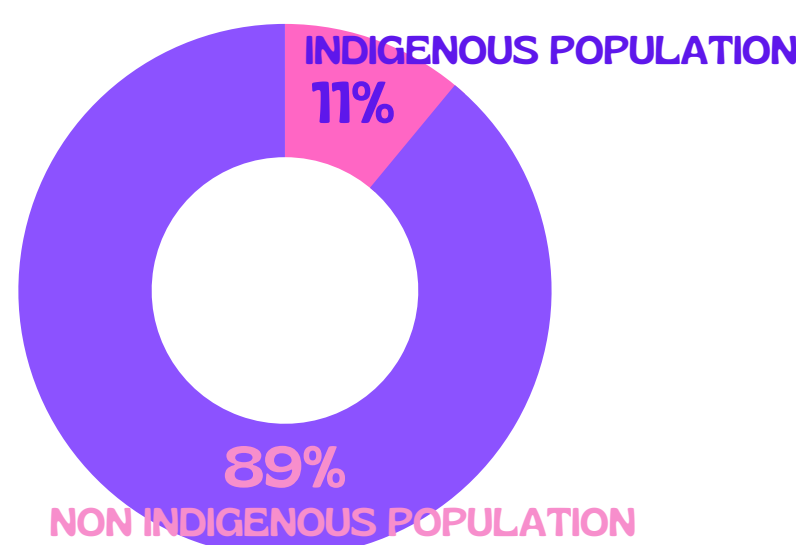
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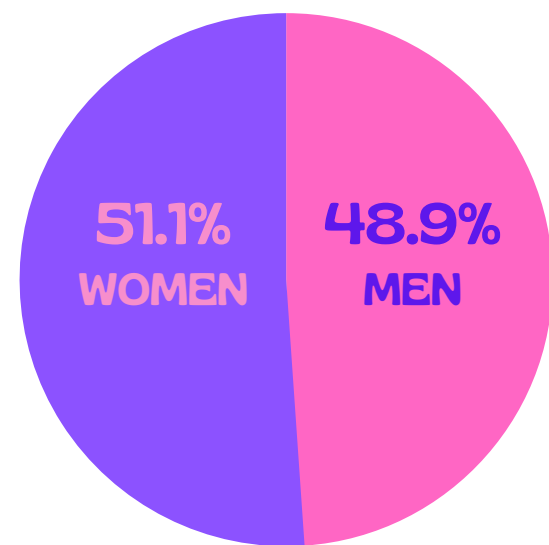
DATA OF THE INDIGENOUS POPULATION IN MEXICO



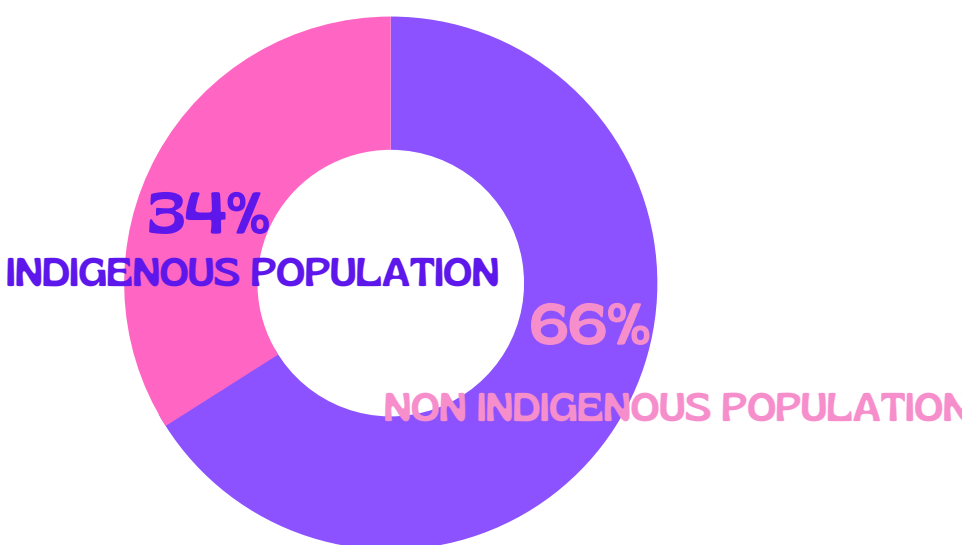
INDIGENOUS POPULATION ACCORDING TO THE SELF DETERMINATION



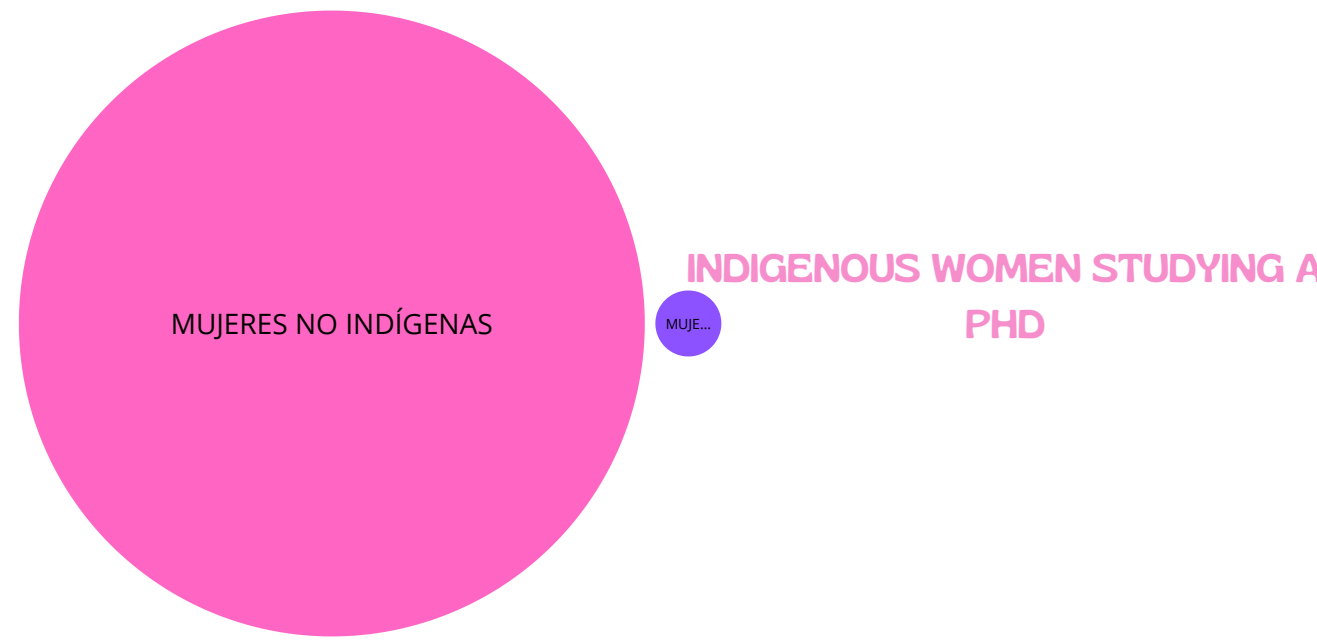
INDIGENOUS POPULATION ACCORDING TO THE LANGUAGE



INDIGENOUS MEN AND WOMEN ACOORDING TO THE LANGUAGE



POPULATION BETWEEN 15 AND 24 YEARS OLD WHO ATTENDS SCHOOL



0.037% OF THE INDIGENOUS WOMEN STUDYING A PHD

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

Gender/Feminist Perspective (Haraway, 1995; Harding, 2012)

This perspective suggests the need to appreciate the perspective of the “oppressed people” due to their race, gender, or class, as these are the main variables that determine “materiality”, allowing an interpretation of the reality of individuals. It also suggests that a transition is necessary to stop seeing women as “objects” to being subjects and authors of knowledge, thus achieving an understanding of the reality experienced by marginalized groups.

Intersectionality (Crenshaw, 1995; Frías, 2022)

This theory suggests that there are multiple types of discrimination in a society that interact with each other; an example of this is the way categories like race and gender intersect and influence women's lives.

Intercultural education (Mateos, Dietz & Mendoza, 2016)

On of its principles is the acknowledgement of the knowledge of indigenous peoples and the need to train professionals committed to their regional “reality”. Its primary objective should be the training of professionals who promote local and regional development in communities, as well as preserving indigenous knowledge and languages.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

-The educational level of the participants' parents seemed to be a factor that impacts the way in which students perceive discrimination.

Results suggest that when parents have primary and secondary education, the perceived discrimination by the participants seems to be primarily focused on gender.

-Findings revealed a lack of confidence in the ability of female students/researchers to carry out their research in their communities. This lack of confidence comes from some members of the community and local authorities, and the participants reported that it stems from well-established social gender roles that still prevail in their communities.

-The experience of indigenous women in the postgraduate program seemed to have sparked the interest of other women from the participants' community to learn about the program and apply to postgraduate studies.

-Once they completed the postgraduate program (i.e., when applying for jobs), participants report experiencing discrimination based on factors related to their personal life when employers asked about issues related to participants' marital status, maternity or plans to get married.